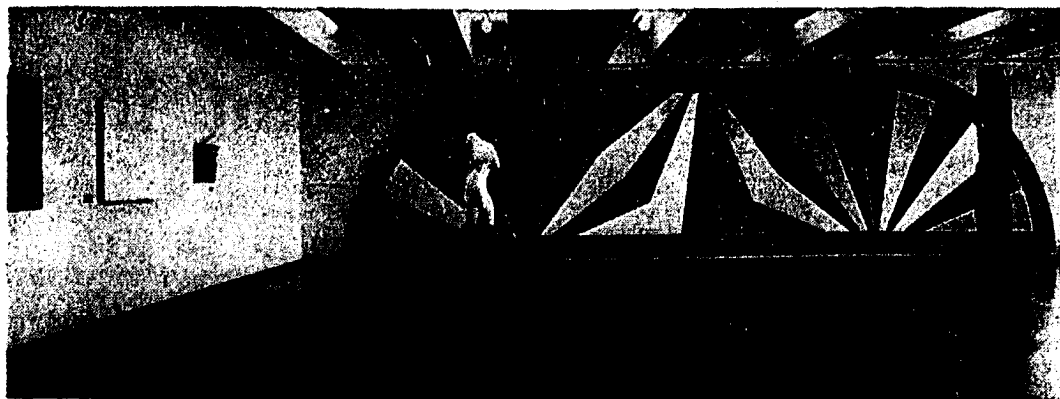




LARGE GALLERY at Smith College's new museum and fine arts complex with Frank Stella's "Damasus Gate" in background.

and fine arts complex with Frank Stella's "Damasus

ARCHITECTURE / By ROBERT CAMPBELL

Marrying modern design to a public art

At the beginning of this series, it might be a good idea to pose the most obvious, but probably the least-asked question there is about architecture.

It's a simple one: Why does nearly everyone still hate modern architecture?

And the corollary question: How can architects find any satisfaction in their work in this situation?

What brought these questions to mind again most recently was the publication of a new book of photographs of American architecture "Notes on American Architecture" by I. Chermayeff. This lovely book ends with a two-page color photo of Peabody Terrace, the Harvard married-student housing complex on the Charles River. The caption, almost adoring, calls it "the epitome of American architecture in the twentieth century."

Not everyone would go that far, but probably most devotees of modern architecture would more or less accept this judgment. The trouble is, having lived in Cambridge for some years, I know perfectly well, and so does everyone else, that if you don't happen to be trained in design, to know Peabody Terrace is to dis-

like it. There are exceptions, of course, but for most people — including highly educated people — the building makes about as much sense, visually, as Sanskrit. They just give up and say: "It's ugly."

Boston City Hall is another example. The magazine "Architectural Plus" recently took the trouble, unusual for an architectural magazine, to ask a number of ordinary Bostonians how they felt about this celebrated building. The interviewer had no difficulty summing up the result: "I was quite stunned to find a body of opinion that was overwhelmingly negative."

But the disagreement over what is good is more than just a split between the architects and the public. Inevitably, the same split infects the architects' own minds. Take the amazing case of Nathaniel Owings, founder and partner in Skidmore, Owings and Merrill. This famous firm virtually invented the bare-bones, "glass box" school of office building design, yet where does Owings himself live? Why, in New Mexico in a rambling, primitive cottage built of handmade adobe bricks, with wood-beamed

ceilings and packed earth floors.

How did Owings discover this quaint gem? He didn't discover it, he designed and built it. His incredible comment: "We never live in a modern setting if we can avoid it. That's for our clients" quoted in (Architectural Forum).

Is Owings unique in his Jekyll-and-Hyde, upside-down world of mixed-up values? I don't think so, not when you think of all the architects who deliberately buy ornate, richly detailed Victorian houses and then feel they must demonstrate their contemporaneity by covering everything inside with white paint or conventional "supergraphics."

The problem isn't in the individuals, it's in our culture. Neither the architects nor the public are going to develop a coherent set of

values unless they begin listening to each other. Architecture is different from other arts like painting and music, where avant-garde artists can happily create works that only a tiny elite understands.

Architecture is a public art, in the sense that we all have to look at and use the buildings that our fellow citizens choose to inflict on us. The small band of believers in modern design have to look at warmed-over "Colonial" housing developments that appear to have been assembled entirely from plastic parts bought at Woolworth's. And the people who live in, and presumably love, those "Colonial" dwellings have to gaze in horror at Peabody Terrace. Meanwhile the visual environment becomes ever more disjointed.

There must be a better way.